happens in every round of golf one plays, nothing has been able to distract me from giving a full 100 per cent while doing an assigned task. Known for being 'cool' under stress, I don't lose my composure easily, and it is not easy to take away the smile from my face no matter how great the challenge or daunting the circumstance. A famous and highly decorated cavalry regiment of ours, The Skinners Horse, has the motto 'Himmat-i-Mardan, Madad-i-Khuda' (God helps the courageous), which is close to my heart. My own regiment, The Maratha Light Infantry, has the credo, 'Duty, Honour and Courage,' which is equally dear to me.

Hard work, sincerity, dedication and destiny bestowed upon me the pride and honour of becoming the first chief of army staff from the elite Maratha Light Infantry Regiment, and the first Sikh to reach this rank. My tenure at the top of the pyramid was of two years and eight months, from 31 January 2005 to 30 September 2007. Regarded by commentators as a soldier, a professional and a thinking general, I brought into limelight that we were not just tough soldiers but that there was a 'humane face' of the army too, that it was a people's army. Zero tolerance was displayed by me with regard to false reporting and human rights violations and the unsound emphasis on 'killings' and the 'numbers' game. In 2007, the army came out with the doctrine of low intensity conflict, in which many of my precepts and ideas have been articulated, the most important one being the concept of an 'iron fist and a velvet glove'.

It is a matter of great pride for me to have been appointed as the governor of Arunachal Pradesh, a strategically important state of our country. The variety of experience that life had in store for me, and the dreamlike army career that took me to the top of the ladder despite some close brushes with death and near-disasters, makes this the story of a survivor and a winner – 'a lambi race ka ghora,' as some friends have described me! Was it destiny or was there an element of luck? Frankly speaking, it has been difficult to fathom everything that has unfolded in life so far.

This then is my autobiography, although strictly speaking, the style is a little unorthodox and different. There is some experimental sketching of my innermost thoughts and a recreation of scenarios, a